for several decades. In fact, braving heavy snow and an overcast sky, several hundred people pushed through the inclement weather to silently hear Rahul Gandhi speak of his encounter with tragedies and consciously related to him as he recounted the dreaded telephone call that brought heartbreaking news twice in his life. I think many silent prayers were made that day in the hope that such news may never be repeated for the young people of Kashmir.

The Yatra's Deeper Purpose

Several states attempted to outperform each other in support of the Yatra, but the short window we got in western Uttar Pradesh (UP) needs to be especially mentioned. Crossing over from east Delhi, which had been traumatized by riots in 2020, the Yatra was met with tremendous enthusiasm, conviction and zeal. It would not be wrong to say that for a while it seemed as if the Congress's years of despondency and defeat were overturned. For those of us in UP who have to sweat to gather large numbers for political meetings, it was immensely encouraging to see such massive crowds of people turn up and enthusiastically walk beside and in the footsteps of the leader.

I especially mention the UP experience because it typifies what the Yatra means for the Congress party. In many ways, the Bharat Jodo Yatra can be seen as a defining moment for the new Congress. For many years the constant message we have got from Rahul Gandhi is to change—change in the way we do politics, change in our social base, change how we view our society, change in the way we treat our compatriots who are not as advantaged as we are. Through the Yatra, he made the entire party organization change. After years of inertia caused by the humdrum of time and routine, something boldly disruptive and innovative was needed to shake up the party. I think the Yatra in that sense was the logical conclusion of Rahul's admirable efforts to reform the party from within. It was an idea whose time had come, and it drove home the need for us to change. But the